During the lockout, the workers had to go without pay. Ratan was troubled by the thought that they would be struggling to buy their necessities. As Shireen and Deanna, who were staying with him at Bakhtavar during the period of the lockout, recall, they would see him come home very upset every day. ‘[He was] so upset thinking about how the workers would feed themselves’ and pushed hard to ‘give them something in kind, like grains’, they say, but the lawyers would have none of it. It made him very ‘desolate’. His constant refrain was, ‘How will they support themselves; we locked them out.’

Despite all the problems, the NELCO experience was rewarding. As Ratan reminisces: ‘I learnt a lot. I do not think I could have learnt as much the hard way as I did at NELCO. I was always put in a firefighting situation.’

The Millstone Mill

In 1974, Ratan was made a director in Tata Sons. It was another new appointment for him. The same year he went to the US to pursue an Advanced Management Programme at Harvard Business School, but by mid-1975, he was back in India and returned to his task of nursing NELCO back to health. It was the only substantial charge he had, but effectively, it changed nothing for him. Ratan was still at the periphery of the Tata Group and was sneeringly dubbed the ‘unknown entity’.

He was concerned that his career was going nowhere. Once again, he started toying with the idea of leaving for the US. In all earnestness, he prepared his ‘résumé’ to send to potential employers outside India. Neatly typed on an electric typewriter, it listed his qualifications and the experience gained in the various posts he had held. And even as he was in the midst of taking a final decision on sending the CV, he received what looked like an irresistible offer from the US.

While at Harvard, Ratan had become friends with Amar Bose, an Indian American academic at MIT and the founder of Bose Corporation, world-renowned for its speakers. Bose offered Ratan the post of president of his company. As a music buff who enjoyed jazz, blues and playing the piano, and who had a self-confessed weakness for quality sound systems, the offer was music to Ratan’s ears.